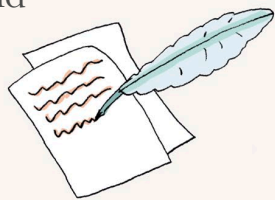


For the son of a prominent person like Ser Piero, formal education would begin with learning to read, write, and do arithmetic.



Leonardo was neither more nor less interested in his studies than most other boys of his age. His lessons were taught in common Italian, not the language of advanced education, Latin. (Leonardo learned this much later and largely on his own.)

Though Leonardo may not have been the most dedicated of students, his time away from the classroom certainly wasn't wasted. When he wasn't studying, he spent long hours wandering the countryside. He became a great collector, of rocks and flowers and bits of wood—anything unusual that caught his attention.

